

Polls boost Democratic odds in House, Senate

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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Eurasia Group is upgrading its odds that Democrats flip the House (90%, up from 85%) and Senate (60%, up from 55%) on the back of a continued polling surge.

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A comfortable Democratic House majority has become more likely, with the party probably flipping just over 20 seats, while a tight Senate race still leaves a 53-seat majority in reach for Democrats.

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The highly left-leaning national environment will limit the efficacy of any last-minute Republican advertising blitzes or populist promises to voters, but the possibility of a 2024-style polling bias is a note of caution for Democrats.

A larger Democratic House majority is now the most likely outcome. Democrats have broken through in the generic congressional ballot, which asks respondents whether they would support the Democratic or Republican candidate in their congressional district. In Silver Bulletin polling average, they lead by 9 points among all voters and 9.6 points among likely voters; their absolute level of support has exceeded 50%, while Republicans' support is falling, a sign that the political environment is not playing to their advantage. Democrats' lead could even increase in the coming week, as a number of high-quality pollsters have recently found 10-point-or-greater leads. This is the best sustained polling for Democrats since at least 2018, and perhaps even earlier.

In this environment, flipping the House is now a near-certainty (90% odds, up from 85%, see "Democrats face narrower pathway to a smaller House majority after Virginia ruling," 8 May 2026), and the size of the likely Democratic majority has increased. Using 2026 district boundaries and assuming a uniform 10.5-point national swing from 2024 presidential results (an R+1.5 national environment), at least 20 districts, and likely more, would flip toward Democrats.

Meanwhile, the likelihood of only a small Democratic flip has receded, as it would require a historically unprecedented move toward Republicans in the generic ballot. A larger majority is good news for Democrats across the board: It will ease the process of electing a speaker and will render the

Democratic majority more resilient to a potential shift back toward Republicans in 2028.

Democrats' outlook in the Senate is improving as pickup opportunities expand. The weekend's set of New York Times/Siena College polls was only the latest in a strong run for Democrats in the battleground states. Democrats hold leads of over a point in five Republican-held states, enough to win a 52-seat majority if they win all their own states. While Minnesota has emerged as a potential upset opportunity for Republicans, Democrats have succeeded in expanding the map elsewhere, with the deep-red Kansas seat now looking like a serious pickup opportunity.

Compared to our last update (see "Democrats are now narrow Senate favorites ," 24 September 2026), the math is shifting in Democrats' direction. Putting more races in play means they can afford a miss or two (such as Maine, see: US Daily, "Maine is no longer a must win for Democrats ," 30 September 2026) while still preserving a route to 51 seats.

Potential polling bias in favor of Democrats is the key unknown. Democratic leads in the battleground states have been durable, with Republicans rarely leading in most states, but they are still small in absolute terms; it would not take large polling misses for Republicans to hold on. In this context, whether the polls behave more like they did in the last two presidential elections—when they significantly overstated Democrats' support—or the last two midterms, when they were not biased in Democrats' favor, is key. If the former occurs, Republicans will at most lose two seats on current polling; if it's the latter, Democrats will win 53 seats.

We think that polling misses in 2020 and 2024 mostly resulted from underestimating Republican support, especially among voters without a college degree, when President Donald Trump was on the ballot, and that there is no reason to expect similar bias this year. However, this kind of polling error is impossible to predict in advance, and the possibility that it recurs is a major reason our odds for Democrats are not higher.

Massive spending is probably too late to reverse the tide for Republicans. Republicans have turned on the money spigot, particularly in Texas, where organizations boosting Republican Ken Paxton spent \$145 million last month, against Democrat James Talarico's \$66 million. But the evidence that spending has swayed voters is scant; Talarico's lead hasn't budged in late-September or early-October polls.

With the national environment so strongly negative—and with Trump's net approval below -20%—we doubt that this tide of advertising will be enough to shift races. Meanwhile, the White House's repeated promises of issuing \$5,000 checks to voters if Republicans sweep the elections have had no discernible impact on voter attitudes. Similar moves, such as Medicare "rebate" payments to seniors or price relief on diesel, aren't likely to move the needle either in this climate.

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